

Squid Games

SQUID GAME WAS the breakout streaming hit show of the Covid era.

Written and directed by Hwang Dong-hyuk, it made its Netflix debut in September 2021. Despite a low budget, violence, and subtitles, it quickly became must-see TV during the pandemic lockdown. *Variety* reported the show was a global phenomenon, racking up 1.65 billion hours of streaming in the first four weeks after its release.³³ Eventually, it became Netflix's most-watched original show, with over 2.2 billion hours viewed. *Stranger Things* and *Wednesday*—in second and third place—are about 500 million hours behind.

It must have been an incredible, obvious success from the onset, with studios tripping over each other to buy such a massive, winning concept, right?

Not even close.

For more than 10 years, the South Korean survival drama was dismissed by the industry as grotesque and unrealistic. *The Wall Street Journal* covered the show's history a few weeks after its debut, after it had become a global phenomenon:

Squid Game creator Hwang Dong-hyuk came up with the idea for the show **more than a decade ago**, while living with his mother and grandmother. He had to stop writing the script at one point: He was forced to sell his \$675 laptop for cash. Back then, potential investors and actors bristled at the brutal killings and implausibility of individuals competing to the death for money.³⁴

It is amazing how many people with experience, expertise, and capital passed on funding what would become the most popular worldwide show of the 2020s.

Before you credit Netflix for recognizing the show's potential, note that is